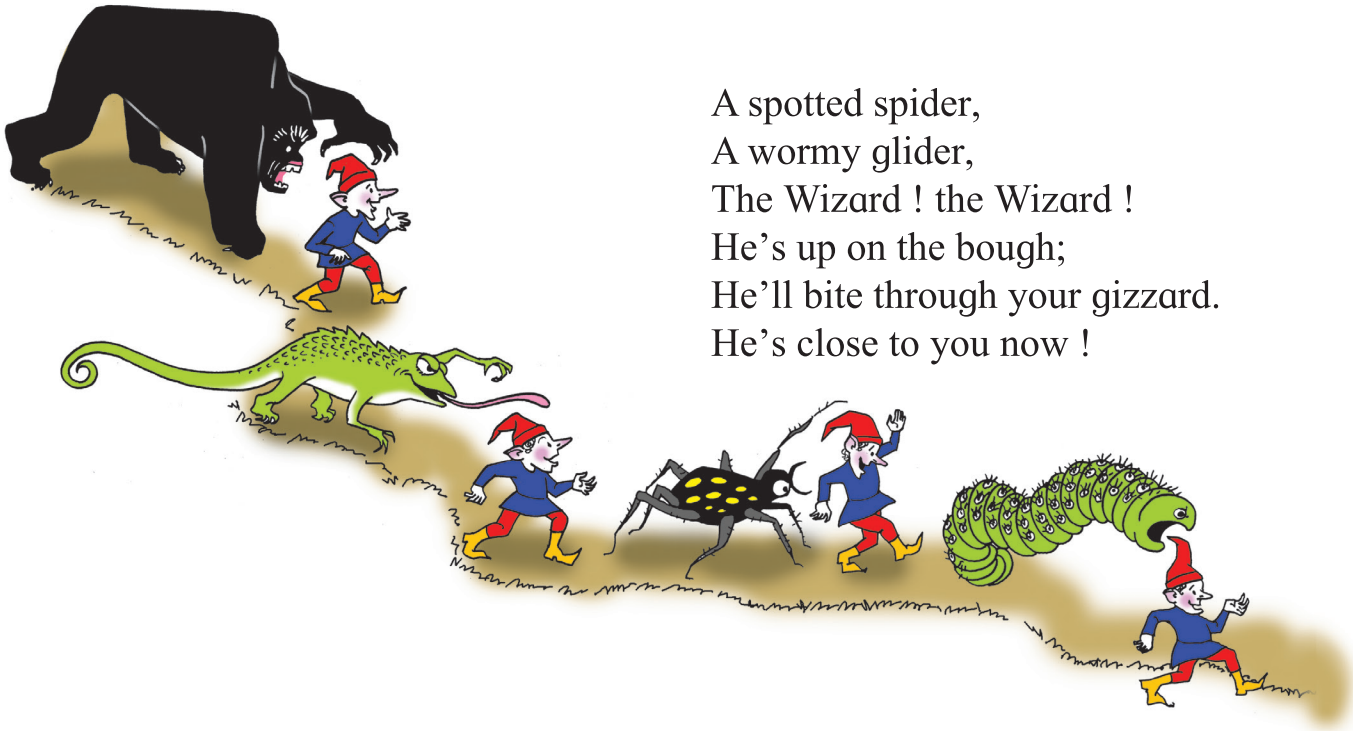
28. The Elf Singing

An Elf sat on a twig.
He was not very big.
He sang a little song,
He did not think it wrong;
But he was on a Wizard's ground,
Who hated all sweet sound.

KNP2H7

Elf, Elf,
Take care of yourself,
He's coming behind you,
To seize you and bind you
And stifle your song.

The Wizard ! the Wizard !
He changes his shape
In crawling along.
An ugly old ape,
A poisonous lizard,



A spotted spider,
A wormy glider,
The Wizard ! the Wizard !
He's up on the bough;
He'll bite through your gizzard.
He's close to you now !

The Elf went on with his song.
It grew more clear and strong.
It lifted him into air.
He floated singing away,
With rainbows in his hair;

While the Wizard-worm from his creep
Made a sudden leap,
Fell down into a hole,
And, ere his magic word he could say,
Was eaten up by a Mole.

– *William Allingham*

- **elf :** an imaginary creature with magical powers.
- **twig :** a small thin stem of wood that grows from a branch on a tree.
- **seize :** take hold of somebody or something.
- **stifle :** stop something from happening.
- **bough :** a main branch on a tree.
- **gizzard :** a part of (a bird's) stomach.
- **ere :** before.
- **mole :** a small dark furry animal.

Things to do :

1. Read the poem aloud.
2. Write the pairs of rhyming words you find in this poem.
3. Complete the following in your own words :

   (a) The elf could sit on a twig because ..... .

   (b) The elf loved ..... .

   (c) The wizard hated ..... .

   (d) If the elf was not careful, the wizard would ..... .

   (e) As the elf's song grew clear and strong ..... .

   (f) The wizard-worm made a leap and ..... and was swallowed up ..... .
4. Discuss the following:

   (a) Why the wizard can take only frightening and ugly shapes.

   (b) Does the elf sing a happy song?